Relative pronouns: who, which, that

Goal: To join two sentences with the relative pronouns who, which and that, to choose the right pronoun for people and things, and to write clear definitions of inventions and inventors.

The idea in two lines: A relative pronoun replaces a repeated noun and links two ideas in one sentence. Use who for people, which for things and animals, and that for both in defining (necessary) clauses.

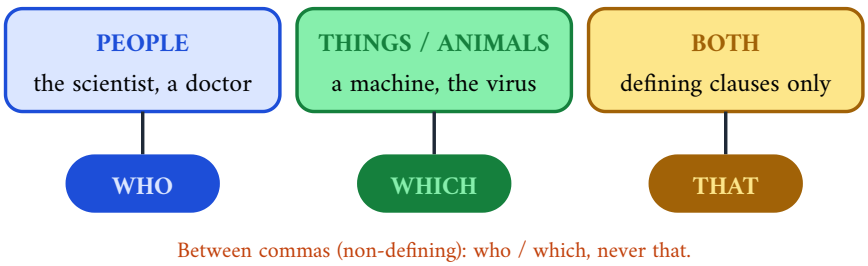


Figure 1: Choosing the relative pronoun according to the noun it replaces.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Relative pronoun:** a word (who, which, that) that introduces a relative clause and replaces a noun already mentioned, so the noun is not repeated.
2. **Who** refers to people: "Louis Pasteur was the scientist who developed the rabies vaccine."
3. **Which** refers to things, animals and ideas: "The telephone is a device which carries the voice."
4. **That** can replace who or which, but only in a **defining clause**, a clause the sentence needs to identify the noun. It is common in speech.
5. **Non-defining clauses** add extra information between commas; use who or which, never that: "Penicillin, which was discovered by accident, saves lives."
6. **Subject or object:** when the pronoun is the object of the clause, it may be left out: "the book (that) I read". When it is the subject, it must stay.

7. **Definitions:** a classic BAC task: "A microscope is an instrument which makes tiny objects look bigger."

🟢 Examples

1. Join: "Graham Bell was an inventor. He invented the telephone." **Answer:** Graham Bell was the inventor who invented the telephone. **Explanation:** "he" refers to a person, so who replaces it.
2. Join: "The X-ray is a technique. Doctors use it to see bones." **Answer:** The X-ray is a technique which (or that) doctors use to see bones. **Explanation:** "it" is a thing and the object of use, so which or that; "it" disappears.
3. Define the word "thermometer". **Answer:** A thermometer is an instrument that measures temperature. **Explanation:** noun + relative pronoun + function.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Keeping the old pronoun after the relative pronoun: "the machine which it works" instead of "the machine which works".
- Using **which** for people ("the doctor which…") or **who** for things.
- Using **that** after a comma in non-defining clauses.
- Forgetting that the verb after who or which agrees with the noun before it: "the scientists who work", not "who works".

🟡 Quick review

- who = people, which = things, that = both (defining only).
- The relative pronoun replaces the noun: do not repeat he, she, it.
- Commas = extra information = who / which, never that.
- Definition formula: X is a person / device which + function.
- Object pronoun can be dropped; subject pronoun cannot.

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